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SSIs are also known as Micro, Small & Medium Enterprises (MSMEs). They are defined and categorized by the Micro, Small & Medium Enterprises Development Act, 2006. The Act categorizes different scale of industries on the basis of investment in plant and machinery in case of manufacturing industries and on the basis of investment in equipment in case of service sector industries.

Agro-based Industries: These industries are based on the processing of agricultural produce. Agro-based industries may be organised on a cottage-scale, small-scale and large-scale. These industries tend to develop household settlements around them as they employ more labour on a regular basis. Examples are textile, sugar, paper, vegetable oil, tea and coffee industries.

10.9 Rural Indebtedness

Rural indebtedness refers to the situation of the rural people unable to repay the loan accumulated over a period. Existence of the rural indebtedness indicates the weak financial infrastructure of our country, in reaching the needy farmers, landless people and the agricultural labourers.

The farmers borrow loan for various purposes like agricultural operations, supporting the family in the lean season or purchase of equipments in the recent years, expenses on celebrations, liquor consumption and medicines go on increasing without any limit. Due to lower income, the villagers are unable to repay the loans or pay the pending interest on the principal amount.

According to the Government of India's Socio Economic and Caste Census (SECC), 2015, around 73 per cent of households in India are rural. Of these, 18.5 per cent are scheduled caste households and 11 per cent belong to the scheduled tribe category.

The data of the National Sample Survey Organisation (NSSO, 2002-03) reveals that only about 30 per cent of the poor borrowers get credit from the formal banks. According to the All India Debt and Investment Survey (AIDIS) 2002, the share of institutional credit has declined from 66.3 per cent in 1991 to 57.1 percent in 2002, with a corresponding increase in informal channels of credit (RBI, 2006).